

WC26 winner — model vs market-anchored favourites

Argentina is the model's favourite, but not the market's. Once the tournament sim is anchored to live Polymarket winner odds — which settle on extra-time/penalties, the correct basis — **France** is the clear favourite and Argentina falls to 3rd–4th. The earlier "Argentina #1" call was a pure Elo artifact.

World Cup winner probability — three weightings

#	Model only w=1.0 · pure Elo+DC sim	Market-anchored w=0.5 · 50/50	Market only w=0.0 · de-vigged PM
1	Argentina 17.8%	France 14.8%	France 18.0%
2	Spain 16.1%	Spain 14.7%	Spain 13.3%
3	France 11.6%	Argentina 14.7%	England 12.6%
4	England 9.8%	England 11.2%	Argentina 11.5%
5	Brazil 9.7%	Brazil 8.1%	Portugal 7.2%
6	Colombia 5.8%	Portugal 5.6%	Brazil 6.5%
7	Germany 4.5%	Germany 5.2%	Germany 5.8%
8	Portugal 4.1%	Netherlands 3.8%	Netherlands 3.9%

Model = 20,000-sim Elo+Dixon-Coles tournament run, conditioned on all 24 played group results (cached fit `data/advancement_models.pkl`). Market = de-vigged Polymarket "World Cup Winner" book (48 teams, overround 1.023). Blend = w·model + (1–w)·market. Argentina shaded amber, France (market favourite) green.

The market moved opposite to the model. Across the matchday-1 window the Polymarket winner price faded Argentina and backed France — so the model's promotion of Argentina is contradicted by where real money actually went.

Live market re-pricing across matchday 1 (Polymarket winner share price)

Team	start	now	move
France	16.5%	18.4%	+1.9 pp
Argentina	14.0%	11.8%	-2.2 pp
Spain	16.0%	13.7%	-2.4 pp
England	13.5%	12.8%	-0.7 pp

Why this is the fix

The advancement sim (`src/wca/advancement.py`) was a 50/50 Elo+DC blend with **no market term**, on the false premise that "no knockout odds exist". They do: Polymarket prices winner, group-winner and reach-stage markets, and their full share-price history is fetchable via `clob.polymarket.com/prices-history`. Anchoring the winner/stage outputs to that de-vigged market (recommended w≈0.5) tempers Elo's single-match over-reaction and brings the favourite ranking in line with where the money is. Outright/advancement stays on its own ET/pens settlement track — never mixed with 90-minute legs.

World Cup Alpha · generated 2026-06-18 · model `src/wca/models/elo.py` + `dixon-coles.py`, sim `advancement.py`; market via `src/wca/data/polymarket.py` + CLOB prices-history. Numbers traced to `/tmp/wc_winner_anchored.json`.